

Pietro Pellerito

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Fields of Interest

Applied Microeconomics - Labor, Public, Economics of Education

Education

Ph.D. Economics, University of Notre Dame	May 2027 (expected)
M.A. Economics, University of Notre Dame	July 2022
B.S. Applied Mathematics, Kettering University Minor - Economics	June 2021

Job Market Paper

“Breaking Boundaries: Competitive Effects of Inter-District School Choice”

Abstract: Inter-district school choice (IDSC), which allows students to attend public schools outside their residential districts, may improve educational quality by exposing districts to enrollment pressure. Yet district responses to expanded access to alternative public schools remain understudied. I exploit an unanticipated Indiana funding reform that eliminated transfer tuition in 2010, sharply reducing household participation costs. Using statewide student-level administrative data, I estimate a continuous difference-in-differences model using districts’ IDSC enrollment-threat exposure, constructed from pre-policy achievement gaps with neighboring districts; districts competing against higher-achieving neighbors face greater enrollment pressure after transfer tuition is eliminated. A one-standard-deviation increase in exposure produces a net enrollment loss through transfers equal to 2.06 percent of district enrollment. The same increase raises district value added, a measure of academic quality, by 0.0074 test-score standard deviations, reducing the initial achievement gap between lower- and higher-exposure districts by 5.3 percent. Gains are concentrated in elementary grades, where the effect reaches 0.0156 standard deviations. Quality rises immediately, while IDSC participation and enrollment shifts develop gradually, consistent with responses to anticipated rather than realized losses. I find no evidence that observed student composition or measured resources explain the quality response. Consistent with enrollment threats, elementary-grade effects are larger in smaller, geographically compact districts, where losses are harder to absorb and alternatives more accessible. These findings identify enrollment incentives as a channel through which reducing IDSC barriers can improve educational quality.

Working Papers

“Staying Connected: Experimental Effects of Weekly Text Messages in an Adult High School”
with Patrick Turner and Alberto Ortega

Selected Works in Progress

“Firm Behavior to Dual Minimum Wage Policies”

with Tim Spilde

“Do ILEARN More? Retention, Resources, and Future Academic Attainment”

Research Experience

Research Assistant to Patrick Turner, University of Notre Dame 2024–2026

Research Assistant to Niharika Singh, University of Notre Dame 2023–2024

Research Assistant to Petros Ioannatos, Kettering University 2020

Teaching Experience

Instructor, University of Notre Dame, Principles of Microeconomics 2024

Teaching Assistant, University of Notre Dame, LP Statistics for Economics 2023

Teaching Assistant, University of Notre Dame, Principles of Microeconomics 2022

Supplemental Instructor, Kettering University, Microeconomics I 2019

Supplemental Instructor, Kettering University, Calculus II 2018

Fellowships, Awards, and Affiliations

Notre Dame Program for Interdisciplinary Education Research (PIER) 2023–2027

Awarded annual \$2,500 research stipend

Graduate Student Research Award 2024

Totaled \$4,000

U.S. Census Bureau Special Sworn Status

Restricted-use data access through Chicago RDC

Wilson Sheehan Lab for Economic Opportunities Research Affiliate 2026–2027

Computational Skills

Advanced: Stata, L^AT_EX, Excel

Proficient: Matlab, Python

Presentations

2026 - Notre Dame Applied Micro Brown Bag; Notre Dame Graduate Student Seminar; Association for Education Finance and Policy; Leuven Economics of Education Research; Association for Mentoring and Inclusion in Economics; Southern Economic Association (Upcoming); Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (Upcoming)

2025 - Notre Dame Applied Micro Brown Bag; Notre Dame Graduate Student Seminar; MidSouth Education Policy Workshop; Midwest Sociology of Education Conference

Other Work Experience

Actuarial Intern, Willis Towers Watson 2018–2020

Purchasing Assistant, LEER Corporation 2017–2018

References

Jim Sullivan (Chair)

Professor of Economics
University of Notre Dame
Email: jsulliv4@nd.edu

Jeffrey Denning

Associate Professor of Educational Policy
University of Texas
Email: jeffdenning@utexas.edu

Patrick Turner

Assistant Professor of Economics
University of Notre Dame
Email: npturner4@nd.edu

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